

TWO OPENINGS

Two ways of starting the same episode of a true crime podcast. Each is about a minute read aloud.

Please have them read to you rather than reading them yourself, in whichever order you are given, and sit with each one for a few seconds before saying anything.

A

A tone. A recorded message begins.

RECORDING. *A woman, quiet, close to the phone.* The woman they found under Stonebridge had a name. It was Kerry. She didn't fall down those steps. He told me she hit her head in her own room and that he moved her afterwards. That's never been in the news.

A door opens somewhere behind her. Keys.

A MAN, distant. Leah?

RECORDING. I have to go.

ALLY. Wait. Where are you.

The line ends.

ALLY. Our tip line keeps three things. A voice, a date, a time. It doesn't keep numbers, because I promised it wouldn't, and that promise is the only reason anybody calls it. So at eighteen minutes past eleven on Tuesday night, it left me with a dead woman who has no surname, a living woman who has no address, and a man who has probably already looked at her phone.

B

ALLY. Maureen Nolan has paid her daughter's phone bill every month since November. The number rings out. She leaves messages anyway, and by now they have all become the same message, which is that she isn't angry and she would just like to know she's all right.

Her daughter has not been all right since November. Her daughter has been dead since November.

She is in a file in this city under five words. Unidentified female, no fixed address. She was found at the bottom of the steps under the Stonebridge Viaduct with one injury to the back of her head, and this city wrote down that she fell.

On Tuesday night, a woman told me her name was Kerry. She told me Kerry didn't fall. She said Kerry hit her head in a room and that a man carried her out afterwards, which is not a thing you know unless somebody tells you.

That woman is living with him. And I don't know where she is.

Two questions

1. **Which one do you need to hear the rest of?**
2. **Would you come back tomorrow for it?**

If you want to say more, say it after you have answered those two. First instinct is the useful thing.